

Angela Bartz (Katsaros) ‘96
Documentation Manager at H2O.ai
abartzmail@gmail.com

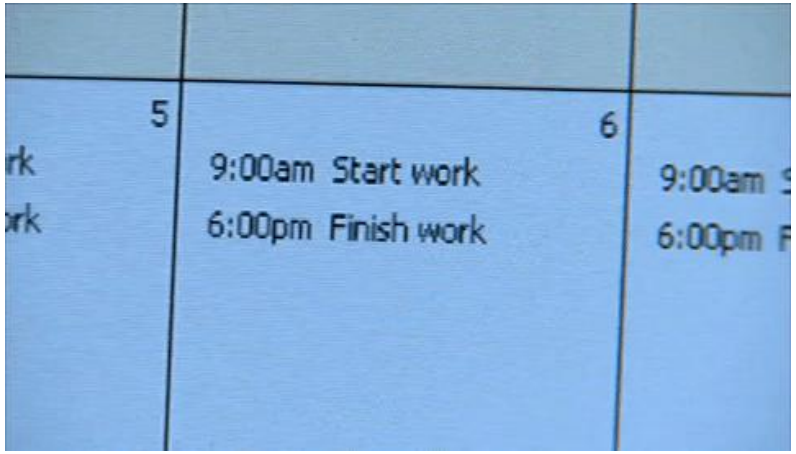
General Info



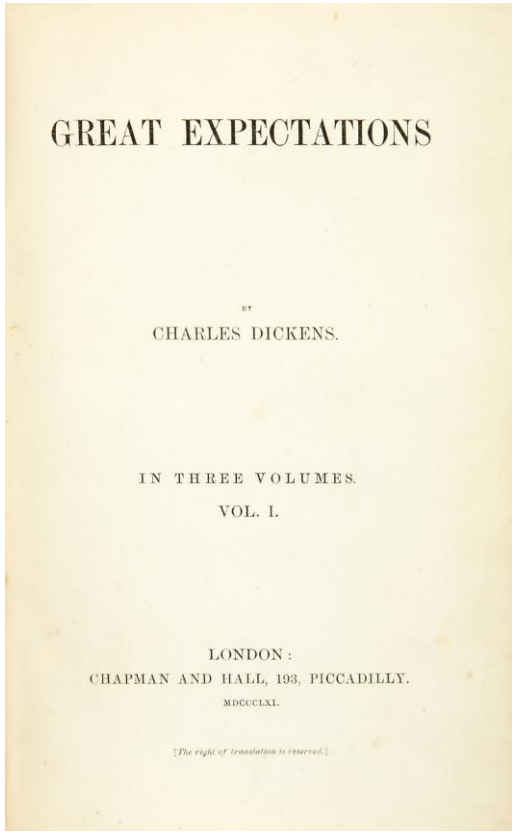
- How I got into tech writing
  - I was at the point where I needed to pick a major and graduate
  - Was a pretty decent writer, but would not be a good teacher
  - Chair of the English department (and my advisor) introduced me to tech writing
- How UDM helped me
  - Smaller class sizes; get to know each of your professors
  - Professors want you to succeed
  - Encouraged working in groups, group study, and group projects
  - Bonus was that there were several tracts

What have I been doing since 1996?

- Took me 2 months to find my first job – writing real estate proposals
- Spent a couple of years in automotive industry editing service and owner's manuals
- Finally broke into software tech writing in 1998
- Moved to CA in 2008
- Moved to WA in 2017



What was expected of tech writers then



GREAT EXPECTATIONS

BY

CHARLES DICKENS.

IN THREE VOLUMES.

VOL. I.

LONDON:

CHAPMAN AND HALL, 193, PICCADILLY.

MDCCCLXI.

[The right of translation is reserved.]

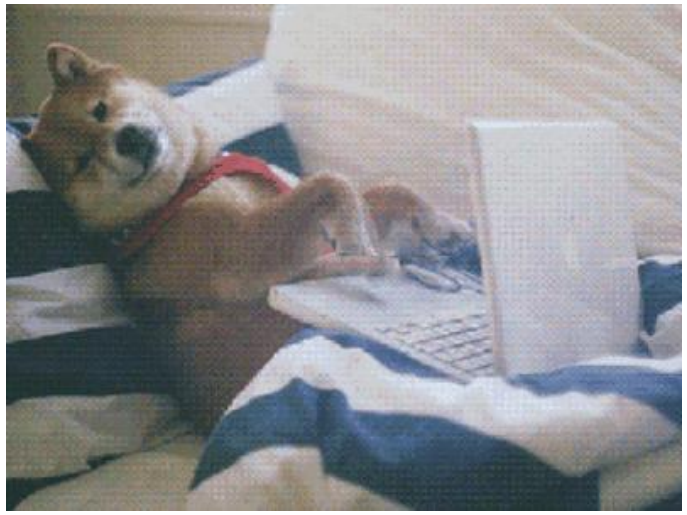
- General Expectations
  - Microsoft Office
  - Graphic software
  - A thick skin. Technical writing is not personal.
- From the late 90's until about 2016, the trend was that tech writers needed a degree in English, communications, or similar and understand the software tools used by the company:
  - FrameMaker
  - RoboHelp
  - Flare
  - Oxygen XML Editor

What’s expected of tech writers today

- The trend in the last couple of years is less of a focus on software tools and more of a basic knowledge of programming languages
  - HTML <- is a must
  - CSS
  - C++
  - Java/Javascript
  - Python
  - R
  - …
- Bonus points for experience with version control software and repositories like GitHub
- Some also ask for experience creating videos
- Searches and Stack Overflow are your friends for when seeking answers to programming questions



“I don’t want to be a programmer.”



- Neither do I ☺
- Don’t worry, you’re not expected to be one, but a basic understanding of programming languages is important
- User manuals often include code samples provided by tech writers
- A basic understanding of the code base makes it easier for tech writers to answer their own questions
  - Often difficult to get information from developers
- Consider taking an audit course in programming languages, if available, or a pass/fail
- But again, HTML is a must
  - Tech writers often maintain the web site for company documentation

“But I don’t understand the technology.”

- For the most part, software technical writers are not expected to be experts in the software genre
  - I’m not an accountant, but I wrote documentation for accounting software
  - I’m not a network engineer, but I wrote documentation for networking protocols
  - I’m not a data scientist or statistician, but I write documentation for machine learning software
- Developers are the experts
  - A good writer knows where to find the right information and/or whom and what to ask
  - This is again where a minimal understanding of one or more programming languages comes in handy
  - A good writer uses the software that he/she is writing about



“Mom, Dad, I’m going to be an English Major!”



- So you’re still considering a job as a technical writer?
- Yes, you can make a decent living
- Full-time annual salary from salary.com
  - Median salary for 1-2 years experience (Technical Writer I)

Boston, MA	Detroit	San Jose, CA
$62,411	$56,217	$66,938

  - Median salary for 7-9 years experience (Technical Writer IV)

Boston, MA	Detroit	San Jose, CA
$115,2326	$103,880	$123, 691

- Spoke with a recruiter recently, and trends in WA are similar to the Bay Area

Even if you’re not an English major

- Written communication skills just as important as verbal
- Working in law enforcement? You need to write detailed and accurate reports or findings of investigations.
- Need to justify new hiring or software purchase or opening a new office or anything that affects the company’s budget. You need a well written proposal.
- Have a question that you need to send to support? The best way to get an answer is to be able to articulate your issue correctly.
- Professionals in scientific fields are required to publish white papers, blog posts, academic research papers.

I’ve just lost my job. Now what?



- This can happen in any career. In software in particular:
  - There are very few successful startups
  - Nepotism does exist
- Don’t panic
- Losing a job can be scary, but also lucrative
- I take a few days for myself before looking for a new job
- Always keep a copy of your resume handy, and update it when you have time
- Keep good contacts on LinkedIn

Recommendations for technical writers

- HTML + CSS course
- One or more additional programming language courses, even if they are audit-only or pass/fail
- If pursuing a technical writing career in software, pay attention to online help systems of other companies to get an idea of trends
- LinkedIn is a great resource for finding jobs and networking with recruiters

Questions?